



from the way demagoguery works. Those of us whose long-term memory is not challenged will remember that this was just how fascism of various kinds thrived in this world. It was always in the name of the 'people', and very soon, one kind of 'people' over another.

Sadly, some of our elected leaders who blinded us by their demonstrations of modernity, have turned out to be closet traditionalists, or just plain political cowards. Many of those who we thought were young, bright and energetic, have already thrown in the towel and given in to traditional casteists. Naveen Jindal, in fact, used his relative youth to plead his way out of a political decision by suggesting he was too young to be so bold and take a stand. Talk of youth being wasted on the young.

The caste census and demands to control caste marriages by law represent double octane backwardness, though it is expressed in a democratic garb. This is not the first time such traditional demands have been made in the name of representing people, but it was called fascism then. That the Left, the centrists and the conservatives in Indian politics lack the nerve to stand up to casteism of this kind only tells us how citizens have been forgotten in the quest for votes.

If this is what democracy is all about, then why did we fight for Independence? The British would gladly have consented to ruling over a people who are internally divisive. They would have happily put in place pre-fabricated walls within which we could have squabbled forever, setting up caste against caste, clan against clan and sect over sect. When we made our Constitution it was supposed to help democracy, and we were once proud of it. Obviously, at some point we were either not paying attention, or we were downright citizen-abusive, that we let caste and other sectional values rule our politics.

Imagine an India in the 21st Century where tourists come in supersonic jets to see brides being burnt, lovers hacked to death, jobs handed out on caste grounds and officials elected on their bigotry appeal. They would marvel at the Indian 'people' who can continue sitting on their haunches, completely oblivious of nano science, clean air, informatics, and rocket science. Here are a people who are not just ignorant, but proud of being that way. That would be our USP in this century and in the centuries to come.

Trust India to aim for the lowest and getting it bang on.

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present established leadership of OBCs."

Again the enumeration will be one-sided as there is no verification of the claims. So mere enlistment in the census cannot be a basis for claiming jobs under a quota. Also, column 40, which is where residents may be asked to declare their caste, may only list caste. Classification will depend on existing norms which differ from state to state. Add to this the politicisation of caste classification. The Gujjars in Rajasthan, who are OBCs, want to be recognised as STs to counter the Meena dominance; Marathas want to be reclassified as Kunbis and get the OBC tag. The OBC tag is different for the same caste in different states. For instance, a Vanjara is an OBC in Maharashtra, an SC in Karnataka and an ST in Andhra Pradesh. And although there are 1,963 castes and around 4,000 sub-castes in the OBC Central list, there will be new demands to expand the list. Aggravating this will be a propensity among those

THE SOCIAL ORDER

The representation of SCs, STs and OBCs in Central Government Services

GROUP	TOTAL POSTS	SCs	STs	OBCs
Group A	80,589	11.9%	4.3%	4.7%
Group B	1,39,958	13.7%	4.5%	2.3%
Group C	20,36,103	16.4%	6.5%	5.9%
Group D*	8,48,398	22.2%	6.72%	4.1%
Total	31,05,048	17.74%	6.39%	5.21%

Of 31,05,048 posts, 5,50,989 are taken by SCs, 1,98,400 by STs and 1,61,818 by OBCs.

Source: Annual report of Ministry of Personnel, Public Grievances and Pensions for 2006-07. Does not include information from two ministries.

** includes sweepers*

lower in the OBC ranks or those who are most backward communities to migrate to SC or ST status. Ergo, whether the OBC count has gone up or not can be determined only if a secondary exercise is undertaken.

Across the 30 states of India, there are many minor and major confrontations simmering for a higher quota of jobs. There are already new demands for reservation, be it reservation in private sector, reservation for religious minorities. And since there are only so many jobs the government can create, political attention is slowly focused on the private sector. Already since 2004, the UPA has been pushing the private sector through the chambers to create a mechanism to make way for a quota for Dalits. The need to fulfill the aspirations of a larger political constituency will only add to this pressure. Even as the Government is wrestling with the methodology on how to enumerate caste, political parties are already getting ready for Mandal-II.